

The movie taps into the traditional fear of the wicked stepparent, a staple of fairy tales. Vidal is uncaring toward Ofelia, even callous toward her pregnant mother, Carmen; he is using his wife solely as a means to produce a son. With her mother bedridden, Ofelia's closest relationship with an adult is with the housekeeper Mercedes, who cares for her when her mother dies in childbirth. In this respect, the movie subverts the traditional fairy tale, because while Vidal very much fits the traditional evil stepparent mold, Mercedes's role shows that family is not simply blood, but whatever works when it comes to support and affection.

Breaking the rules

Obedying rules, even if morally wrong, is integral to Vidal's world view. He tortures a partisan for

“The portal **will only open** if we offer the **blood of an innocent**. Just a drop of blood: **a pinprick**, that's all. It's the **final task**.”

The faun / Pan's Labyrinth

information, and when the doctor puts the dying man out of his misery, Vidal is genuinely puzzled. When asked why he disobeyed, the doctor replies contemptuously, “Captain, to obey—just like that—for obedience's sake, without questioning, that's something only people like you do.” At that, Vidal shoots the doctor, even knowing that in doing so, he is putting his wife's life at risk.

Later, in the fairy story, Ofelia is given a frightful order handed down to her by the faun. In one of the

movie's most powerful moments, we ask ourselves whether she can truly prove she is better than Vidal, and if good can still vanquish evil.

One common criticism of fantasy movies is that they lack a grounding in humanity. *Pan's Labyrinth* is a retort to this, a movie deeply rooted in emotion even as it dreams up terrifying monsters. ■

The child-eating Pale Man, whom Ofelia encounters during her second task, is a nightmarish creation—but the real monsters are all too human.

